gets a bit complicated. If the idea is to win everyone's affection, parties must speak to universal needs. Nothing puts all the tiles of the mosaic together like agriculture. Almost every caste is connected to the land and tilling. And in a segment that lives on risk and financial insecurity, the promise of state support is relevant to all. No wonder, then, that all manifestos spell out a plethora of guarantees for the *annadata* (see *What's Promised to Them*).

The last available government data on agricultural households—collected during the 77th round of the National Sample Survey (NSS) in 2019, for the July 2018-June 2019 period—suggests that they account for 54 per cent of rural households in the country. In fact, 21 per cent of rural households are entirely dependent upon farming. But in the past two decades, even as the country's gross domestic product (GDP) has expanded at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 6-7 per cent, the agriculture sector has grown at just about 4 per cent annually.

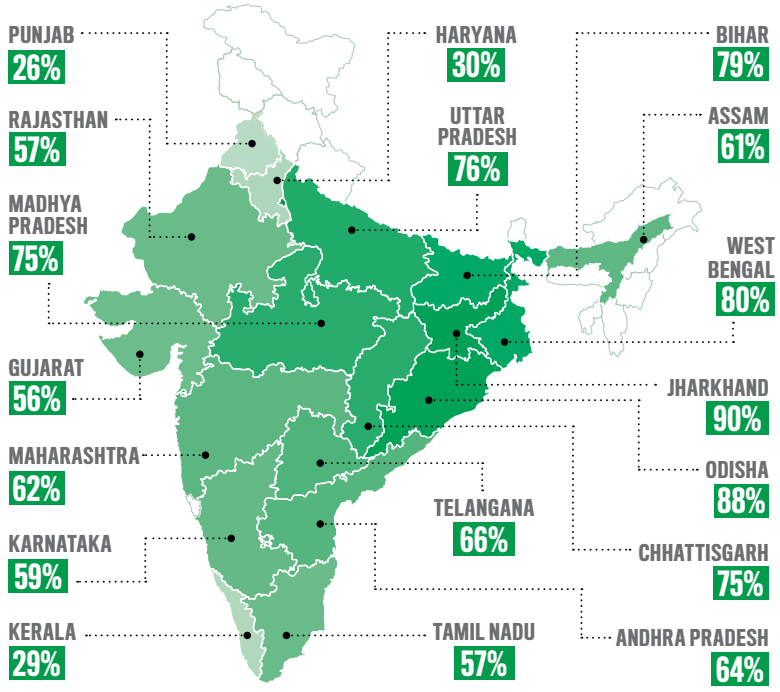
In February 2016, addressing a rally in the run up to the Uttar Pradesh assembly election, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had committed to doubling farm incomes. According to the NSS data, the average monthly income for agriculture households had reached Rs 10,218 in 2018-19, from about Rs 6,426 in 2012-13. This data is not inflation-linked and doesn't reflect the doubling of the real income for farmers, even as the Modi regime has tailor-made social sector schemes to add to rural incomes. The PM Kisan Samman Nidhi, for instance, under which farmers are getting an annual financial assistance of Rs 6,000 as a direct benefit transfer. But data shows that nearly 70 per cent of agricultural households are still earning less than Rs 10,000 monthly (see *The State of Farmers*). Yet, at political rallies or in the BJP's *sankalp patra* (manifesto), the commitment to double the farm income is now missing and the party leaders instead talk about boosting infrastructure at the farm gates and improving market access. This does work for the farmers elsewhere, but not in Punjab and Haryana, where government agencies are already carrying out assured procurements of the farm produce at a pre-decided MSP.

In the past 10 years, the BJP government may have made reasonable efforts to reduce input costs for farmers, but challenges persist in ensuring remunerative output prices. Battling poor yields—both in terms of quality and quantity—and fluctuating prices, farmers in Punjab and Haryana heavily rely on government agencies to buy their produce at MSP, which is officially announced for 23 crops and acts as a safety net if market prices drop below the declared rate. In Punjab, for instance, nearly 85 per cent of the farm produce reaching *mandis* is procured by government agencies at MSP.

In 2020, the Modi regime tried to introduce structural reforms in the sector by pushing through three farm laws.

THE STATE OF FARMERS

EVEN AS THE AVERAGE MONTHLY INCOME OF AGRICULTURAL HOUSEHOLDS TOUCHED RS 10,218 IN 2018-19, A LARGE PROPORTION CONTINUES TO SUSTAIN ON MEAGRE MEANS–AS MANY AS 68% HAD TOTAL MONTHLY INCOME LESS THAN RS 10,000. FOLLOWING IS A STATEWISE BREAKUP



Source: NSS 77th round (for the July 2018-June 2019 period)

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